

duty of watching the enemy, and gave himself up to enjoyment. The feast of which we read in Daniel, and which suffered such an awful interruption, may have been in part a religious festivity,¹ but it indicates nevertheless the self-indulgent temper of the king, who could give himself so entirely up to merriment at such a time. While the king and his "thousand nobles"² drank wine out of the sacred vessels of the Jews, the Persian archers entered the city, and a scene of carnage ensued. "In that night was Belshazzar slain."³ Amid the confusion and the darkness, the young prince, probably unrecognised by the soldiery, who would have respected his rank had they perceived it,⁴ was struck down by an unknown hand, and lost his life with his kingdom.

26. Cyrus then, having given orders to ruin the defences of the city,⁵ proceeded to the attack of Borsippa, where Nabonadius still maintained himself. But the loss of his capital and his son had subdued the spirit of the elder prince, and on the approach of the enemy he at once surrendered himself.⁶ Cyrus treated him with the gentleness shown commonly by the Persians to those of royal dignity,⁷ and assigned him a residence and estates in Carmania, forming a sort of principality, which has been magnified into the government of the province.⁸ Here, according to Berosus, he ended his days in peace. Abydenus, however,

¹ See Herod. i. 191. *τυχεῖν γὰρ σφι ἐοῦσαν ὀρτήν*. The religious character of the festival is indicated in the book of Daniel by the words—"They drank wine, and praised the gods of gold, and of silver, of brass, of iron, &c." (verse 4).

² Dan. v. 1.

³ Ibid. verse 30.

⁴ Cræsus nearly lost his life in the same way, amid the confusion consequent upon the taking of his capital by assault, but was spared as soon as his rank was indicated (Herod. i. 85).

⁵ We are generally told, when the capture of Babylon by an enemy is related, that the defences are *demolished*. Berosus said that Cyrus ordered the outer defences to be razed to the ground (*συντράξας τὰ ἔξω τῆς πόλεως τεῖχῃ κατὰ σκάψαι*, Fr. 14, sub fin.). Herodotus makes Darius *remove* the wall, and tear down the gates, adding that Cyrus had left them standing (*τὸ τεῖχος περιεῖλε, καὶ τὰς πύλας ἀπέσπασε· τὸ γὰρ πρότερον ἔλawn Κύρος τὴν Βαβυλῶνα ἐποίησε τούτων οὐδέτερον*, iii. 159). Arrian tells us that Xerxes razed to the ground (*κατέσκαψε*) the temple of Belus (Exp. Alex. vii. 17; compare iii. 16). In every case there is undoubtedly an exaggeration. The conqueror was satisfied to dismantle the city, without engaging in the enormous and useless labour of demolition. He broke, probably, large breaches in the walls, which sufficed to render the place defenceless. When a revolt occurred, these breaches were hastily repaired, and hence Babylon could stand repeated sieges—one at the hand of Cyrus, a second and third during the reign of Darius, and a fourth during that of Xerxes (Ctes. Exc. Pers. § 22). The walls must have remained at least to this last occasion; and certainly Herodotus writes as if he had himself seen them (Herod. i. 178 and 181; see Mr. Grote's note, Hist. of Greece, vol. iii. pp. 395–8). Ctesias too appears to have represented himself as an eye-witness of their grandeur (cf. Diod. Sic. ii. 7. *τὸ ὕψος ἀπίστον τοῖς ἀκούουσιν, ὥς φησι Κτησίας ὁ Κνίδιος*). Abydenus, it must be remembered, expressly declared that the wall of Nebuchadnezzar continued to the Macedonian conquest (see above, page 412, note ¹), and St. Jerome says that the old walls of Babylon had been repaired and served as the enclosure of a park in his day (Comment on Esaiam. xiv. vol. iii. p. 115).

⁶ Beros. Fr. 14 sub fin.

⁷ See Herod. iii. 15, and note ad loc.

⁸ Berosus only said—*χρησάμενος Κύρος φιλανθρώπως (τὸν Ναβόννηδον), καὶ δοὺς οἰκητήριον αὐτῷ Καρμανίαν, ἐξέπεμψεν ἐκ τῆς Βαβυλωνίας*. But Abydenus declared—*τὸν δὲ (Ναβαννίδοχον) Κύρος ἔλawn Βαβυλῶνα, Καρμανίης ἡγεμονίᾳ δωρέεται* (Fr. 9).